

One Choice Changes Everything

CHOOSE YOUR WORK



Redefine Success and Discover the Work
That Makes You Feel Fully Alive

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The Unexpected Gifts Hidden in Your Struggles

How to extract insights from your greatest challenges so they become pathways for growth.

What Do the Leaning Tower of Pisa, Improvised Jazz, and Japanese Pottery Have in Common?

The Leaning Tower of Pisa was created by accident. A mistake made during its construction in 1173 caused the tower to tilt. In fact, the defective structural design had to be stabilized from a 5.5-degree tilt to a 3.97-degree tilt in the 1990s for safety reasons. Yet this unintentional defect has become one of its most celebrated features, drawing visitors from around the world. The defect created the beauty.

When musicians play improvised jazz, by definition, they do not follow the notes on the score. We delight in the new melodies formed by the deviation from the planned composition.

Imagine a shattered teacup, not discarded, but painstakingly pieced back together, the cracks filled with shimmering gold. This is *kintsugi*, a practice in Japanese pottery that sees beauty in imperfections. Instead of hiding the flaws, they are accentuated, creating a unique and beautiful piece of art.

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The Leaning Tower of Pisa, improvised jazz, and the Japanese art of *kintsugi* highlight how there is beauty in the unexpected, the irregular, the interruption of the pattern. You are no different. Your specific challenges are a high-definition image of your authenticity. No one else has experienced your difficulties with the level of detail and clarity that you have. Your challenges contain seeds of brilliance that you can use to create distinctive work.

The challenging experiences that leave you feeling shattered are not meant to be hidden. Just as the *kintsugi* artisan carefully restores each crack, you too can pick up the fragments of your past and begin the process of golden repair.

Just as a jazz musician is valued for their unique melodies, you too will find success by tackling issues connected to your personal struggles. The first step is to recognize that you are not your work.



Figure 2: The practice of kintsugi accentuates flaws by filling them with gold.
View and download this photo in full color at:
ChooseYourWorkBook.com/kintsugi

You Are Not Your Work

The most common reaction that people have when they think back to emotionally challenging experiences is, “Oh, I just wasn’t good enough.”

That’s very different from writing an article and wondering, “Is this a high-quality article?” This is a great question to ask because it will help you identify the criteria for high-quality work. By knowing these criteria, you will write a better article.

Observe the difference between “Is this a high-quality article?” and “Am I a good writer?” When you ask the latter question, you might hesitate and lower your self-worth. This leads to a feeling of despair. Instead of facing challenges and giving them your best shot, you get swept up in a mixture of overthinking and insecurity.

So how do we separate the two? Challenge the quality of your work, but never challenge your self-worth. At your core, you are whole. Nothing can diminish your inherent value.

You can further improve the quality of your work by changing “Is this a high-quality article?” to “What could make this article better?” This more specific approach avoids the heightened emotion connected to the vague “This is great” versus “This is terrible.” Your most perceptive insights emerge when you sit behind the article and contemplate both its strengths and weaknesses. Notice how this has everything to do with the article and nothing to do with you.

In the same way that you separate the quality of your work from the quality of yourself, it is equally important to distinguish between what happened in the past and who you are today. You are not your work. You are not your profession. You are not the situations you have encountered. You are something far greater.

In light of this separation, let’s now examine what happens if you fail to confront your past challenges.

The Problem with Ignoring a Challenging Experience

When I was working in the corporate world, I was emotionally disconnected from my work. My initial discomfort wasn't a sharp pain that was strong enough to compel change. Instead, it was more like a dull, recurring ache, the kind that lingers in the background and slowly wears you down. A persistent gray fog, absent of both joy and sadness, settled over my daily lukewarm mediocrity.

Some people suffer their entire lives with this familiar discomfort to the point that they stop noticing it. I eventually realized that when I numbed myself to one feeling, I actually numbed myself to all feelings. By failing to engage with my emotions, I was trapped in a maze of indecision, constantly second-guessing my choices and desires.

When you ignore your feelings, you are more likely to get stuck in unsatisfying work. The only thing worse than doing unsatisfying work is pretending that it's not a problem.

When you notice pain, feel the pain. When you notice joy, feel the joy.

Think back to a time in your past that was both emotionally intense and difficult to navigate. Pause to recall the specific sensations that you remember experiencing. Only by fully feeling the moment can you comprehend its larger significance.

Here is a series of comparisons by psychologist Steven C. Hayes to help you feel an experience more fully. For each comparison, pause long enough to connect it to a challenging experience.

Hold your experience like a delicate flower in your hand.

Embrace your experience like a crying child.

Sit with your experience like you would sit with a person with a serious illness.

Look at your experience like you would look at an incredible painting.

Walk with your experience like you'd walk while carrying a sobbing infant.

THE UNEXPECTED GIFTS HIDDEN IN YOUR STRUGGLES

Honor your experience like you'd honor a friend by listening carefully even if it was hard.

Inhale your experience the way you would take a deep breath.

Abandon the fight like a soldier putting down the weapon and walking home.

Take in your experience like a glass of pure cold water.

Carry your experience like a picture in your wallet.

In business, I've faced several setbacks. These comparisons have been invaluable in helping me to peacefully reconnect with a challenging experience, reframe it, and gain clarity. They have helped me realize that compassion is not just important for the sake of being kind to others. We are all grappling with our own internal struggles. By recognizing that most people are doing the best they can with what they have, compassion helps you to see more clearly.

Now that you have felt your challenging experience more fully, the next step is to let it go.

The Rock Concert

We're now going to transform your challenging experience into something new by doing an activity together.

Take a moment to revisit the experience and concentrate on a specific feeling it evokes. It could be anxiety — the tension or unease from a perceived threat. Maybe it's sadness — a heaviness or sorrow weighing on your mind. You might feel anger — a sense of resentment or irritation toward a situation or a certain person. Perhaps it's guilt — the feeling of responsibility for something that went wrong. Or maybe it's disappointment — the letdown when expectations are not met. Whichever emotion you notice, allow yourself to feel it fully for ten seconds.

Imagine you're standing in front of the stage at a rock concert, close enough to touch the performers. You don't just hear the music; you feel it reverberating through every bone in your body. The pounding bass

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echoes in your chest as the scent of smoke and sweat mingles in the air around you. Strobe lights flash intensely, painting the crowd in rapid, fleeting bursts of color.

This rock concert is a metaphor for your challenging experience — intense, overwhelming, and transformative. Don't engage with any words or thoughts. Just surrender to the raw sensation of the moment, letting it wash over you and carry you away on a tide of pure emotion.

Now imagine you're in a helicopter above the concert. With binoculars, you zoom in and see yourself immersed deeply in the rock concert, immersed in that painful experience. But when you take away the binoculars, you see everyone else at the concert. You can see the band, the lights, and thousands of people. You become a witness to the experience. Instead of being swept up by the emotion, you sit back in your seat and relax behind it, looking at the scene from a distance.

You stay with it. You don't comment. You simply observe it. You see it in its entirety, and then... you let it go. The helicopter departs from the scene. You look back toward the concert as it gets smaller and smaller and then disappears.

You are no longer there. The concert is now in the past. You are here in the present. It's a prior experience. It's not you. And as you let it go:

- Breathe in the difficulty for four seconds... and breathe out for six seconds and let it go...
- Breathe in the difficulty for four seconds... and breathe out for six seconds and let it go...
- Breathe in the difficulty for four seconds... and breathe out for six seconds and let it go...

And you notice that you now feel a little bit lighter.

Look at the fragments of your experience. Were they broken, chipped, shattered? Take a breath. Imagine you're a *kintsugi* master, picking up the

pieces of this experience. As you allow gold to flow through the cracks, what was once pain is now transformed into beauty.

The experience is still part of you, but it no longer defines you. It transforms into something beautiful and strong that will guide you in the next stage of your journey. The transformation not only enriches your life, but by letting go of the past, you are able to make space for the future. With a lighter load, you are much better positioned to discover the work that you are meant to do.

Who Am I Now?

Too often we criticize our prior actions — even those from several years ago — to the point that we let them distort our present experience. Yet the cells in our bodies are replaced daily. In about ninety days, most of your roughly 30 trillion cells will transform into new ones. You are not only a more mature and experienced person with evolved thinking patterns; you are also a biologically different person from who you were several years ago.

If you were exactly the same person you were many years ago, you might be angry with yourself because you may repeat the same behavior. But you are a different person now. Even if you wanted to, replicating the past would be almost impossible. Yes, breathe a huge sigh of relief because the past is over and done with. You will still face challenges, and even if elements of the past repeat, knowing the future will differ from the past should bring you some joy. As your capacity to respond grows, you will have new, richer, and more interesting experiences than ever before.

After even a mildly intense experience, it can be interesting to ponder: Who am I now? How have I evolved? The answer: it's a mystery. You never quite know exactly who you are. All that you can be sure of is that you have grown. Maturity is about accepting the flux of life and recognizing that failure is baked into the process of growth.

How Your Challenges Help You Grow

Rabbi Harold Kushner reflected on the death of his son, who tragically passed away from a rare genetic disease at just fourteen years old. He said:

I'm a more sensitive person, a more effective pastor, a more sympathetic counselor because of Aaron's life and death than I would've been without it. And I would give up all those gains in a second if I could have my son back. If I could choose, I would forego all of the spiritual growth and depth, which has come my way because of our experience. But I cannot choose.

He not only accepted what happened, but he learned from it, grew from it, and moved forward. That's what we want to do now. We must take this difficult experience and move beyond acceptance. We must use it as a springboard to grow.

Viktor Frankl, an Austrian psychiatrist, personifies such growth. While trapped in the atrocities of a concentration camp, he articulated a profound truth with exceptional clarity:

We who lived in concentration camps can remember the men who walked through the huts comforting others, giving away their last piece of bread. They may have been few in number, but they offer sufficient proof that everything can be taken from a person but one thing: the last of the human freedoms — to choose one's attitude in any given set of circumstances, to choose one's own way.

To help survive these atrocious conditions, Frankl wrote notes about his work and hid them in his coat. He was dedicated to his craft for his entire lifetime. He knew what he stood for. For Frankl, psychiatry wasn't merely a profession. It was a calling. He knew that he was sent to do this work. So he did it, and he did it exceptionally well. Indeed, after being freed from the concentration camp, Frankl wrote his groundbreaking book *Man's Search for Meaning* in just nine days.

Sixty-nine years after Viktor Frankl wrote his book, Anthony Ray Hinton was released from prison in another part of the world. After

being framed by the police, Hinton was wrongfully imprisoned for a full thirty years, spending almost his entire time on death row. His Alabama prison cell was infested with rats and cockroaches. He was given scarcely enough food to survive. He spent barely fifteen minutes a day out of his cell. He heard the shrieks of other cellmates being executed in the electric chair. Then the odor of death filled the air, leaving a grim reminder of the execution that occurred just meters away.

How would you respond to these living conditions? While most would lose their composure, Hinton responded with a level of character that we can only hope to emulate, an inimitable ability to transcend the horrific conditions he endured and the gross injustice so mercilessly inflicted upon him. Recounting his experiences, this great man echoed the wisdom of Viktor Frankl, stating:

Despair was a choice. Hatred was a choice. Anger was a choice. I still had choices and that knowledge rocked me... I could choose to give up or to hang on. Hope was a choice. Faith was a choice. And more than anything, love was a choice.

While falsely imprisoned, Hinton established a book club for fellow inmates. After his release, instead of retreating into a private life, Hinton did the opposite. He devoted himself to public speaking, offering hope to those confronted by injustice. His quiet strength and powerful message resonated globally as he harnessed the transformative power of suffering to uplift the lives of others. Hinton's lost years behind bars fueled his public speaking with an intense energy that deeply impacted the lives of those who heard him speak.

Kushner, Frankl, and Hinton each accomplished something very rare. They mastered the art of emotional judo. Judo is the art of using your opponent's weight to redirect their force instead of confronting it head-on. Similarly, emotional judo harnesses negative emotions so that, instead of letting them weaken you, their weight elevates you to a higher level of consciousness. These men transcended their situations by choosing hope over despair, offering us a profound example of how to live.

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These experiences highlight that while there will always be challenges, the inescapable question is: Are you willing to use the force of these difficulties to create a transformation? These experiences are valuable because they give you depth, mold your character, and improve the quality of your thinking. As Camus put it, “In the depths of winter, I finally learned that within me there lay an invincible summer.”

These men also teach us how struggles can become the driving force behind work that is personally fulfilling and valuable to others. Just as Frankl further excelled in psychology and Hinton devoted himself to advocating for justice, you too can establish a new path illuminated by your challenging experiences.

Hopefully, you haven’t endured a fraction of the atrocities faced by Kushner, Frankl, or Hinton. However, if you hadn’t struggled at all, you wouldn’t appreciate the contrast between your past and present. More importantly, you can use these past struggles as seeds to cultivate something beautiful. The pain loses its sting when you absorb its lesson.

This is just the first stage of your journey. Your past challenges are here to help you navigate the next stage.

As the Zen proverb states, *Who knows what is good or bad luck?* It is easy to fall into the trap of believing that getting what you want will create the best experience for you. But more often, it is in the thick of challenging experiences that you uncover hidden gems. It is in these experiences that you break barriers, change perceptions, and create memories that leave an indelible mark on your life.

How to Channel Your Emotions to Build Something Remarkable

When John Wilson was twelve years old, his chemistry class participated in a routine experiment involving boiling water. Unfortunately, a lab assistant had mislabeled a bottle, so instead of boiling water, John boiled a much more reactive substance. The substance caused the container to

explode, shattering many glass bottles. Tragically, John Wilson left that science experiment completely blind.

Most people would be devastated, sink into depression, and lose hope. But John just got on with it. He quickly learned to read Braille, became an accomplished rower, swimmer, and actor, and studied law at Oxford University.

At age twenty-seven, he found himself in Africa. He noticed that blindness was far more prevalent there than in the Western world due to a lack of medical resources. He reflected on how his blindness resulted from an accident and grew angry that millions of others were blind simply due to insufficient resources. Something had to be done, so John established several organizations that helped prevent blindness in tens of millions of people.

If Sir John Wilson could turn his deeply unfortunate experience into a project that helped millions of people, what might be buried in your challenging experience, waiting to be uncovered? Observe the mixture of anger, frustration, and compassion that John felt and how he channeled that energy into something useful. Now, tap into the emotions that your challenges elicit. Feel the emotion deeply. Just as the *kintsugi* artist fills the cracks with gold, use the energy that comes from your challenges to create something that matters to you. Choose the work that fills the cracks with gold.

The Value of Writing About Challenges

When you write about your challenges, you release ideas that were taxing your mind. You expel negative emotions from your body. What once burdened your mind and strained your body now exists in its own place, on its own sheet of paper, separate from you. Now that you are no longer gripped by this narrow emotional focus, you can broaden your gaze and consider related thoughts. This is how you develop perspective.

The more you write, the more your writing reveals to you that you are not your thoughts. You are not your experiences. Your thoughts and

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experiences are separate from you because you are something far greater. You grow to discover that emotions stemming from difficult experiences have a perverse allure, leading you to replay them over and over in your head. But when you write about the experience and let it go, you uncover its hidden value as you progress to the next stage of your growth.

The Hidden Gift

Reflecting on the challenging experience visualized in this chapter:

1. What is the strongest emotion that surfaces when I think about my challenging experience? (e.g., fear, gratitude, relief, frustration)
2. As I sit with this emotion, what emerges as truly important? What have I learned about myself from this experience, and how have I grown from it?
3. Based on what I have learned, what is a project that I would love to pursue?

Duration

Two minutes per question

Feel free to extend this reflection if you're finding it valuable. Writing about challenges can be emotional, so be gentle with yourself. Through this reflection, you're beginning the process of transforming your challenges into sources of strength and insight.

Like the *kintsugi* master carefully mending cracks with gold, you're finding beauty and clarity in your struggles. Let this new perspective guide your choice of work. Perhaps a past experience revealed a hidden strength or highlighted a problem you're now driven to solve. Connect the dots between past and present to envision a project that feels less like a job and more like a calling.

Since this activity is more emotional than others, many find that writing by hand is the best way to complete it.

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In the Next Chapter...

Embracing your struggles sets the stage for profound transformation. You know what else holds you back? Suffering in comfort. Next, we will examine how to overcome this and redefine what success means to you.

3

Don't Confuse Success with Suffering in Comfort

*Why your focus on comfort is ruining your life and
obscuring the true metrics of success.*

The Mysterious Nature of Time

When you witness a child's birth, admire an extraordinary view, laugh heartily with friends, or savor a delicious meal, it's unlikely that you think about your financial situation. Why is that? Such raw human experiences often remind us that some of life's richest moments have nothing to do with money.

What do you think of at times like these? Actually, you don't think. Your experience exceeds your ability to think. Time stands still. You are in the here and now. You are so tightly integrated with the experience that you transcend the mundane distractions that characterize ordinary living. Your capacity to fully participate in each moment is perhaps your most precious gift.

I'm sure that you've had occasions at work when you were so engrossed in a project that you lost track of time, just like when you gazed at a beautiful view. But sadly, for many of us, most of the workday is not an enriching experience. In fact, it's barely an experience at all.

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In the modern world, we typically use time as a sterile means to achieve an objective. We want results and we want them now. We have become obsessed with being productive at the expense of taking the time to enjoy the creative process. We are told to “do the work” when the real priority should be to choose the work that makes us feel fully alive. How did society collapse to the degree that time feels less like an experience and more like a commodity to be consumed?

The arc of history is revealing. Before the Industrial Revolution, societies mainly operated on solar time, which was imprecise because it depended on the sun’s position in the sky. Work followed the natural rhythms of the day and the season.

The Industrial Revolution began in the 1760s and changed everything. The invention of the steam locomotive required standardized time zones for train timetables. Before then, each city had maintained its own local time, so a short journey could place you in a city with a ten-minute time difference. This caused all sorts of problems for the railway companies and even led some to invent their own standard time zones. In fact, modern time zones were invented by Sir Sandford Fleming, a Canadian railway engineer.

The railway companies had won. Time was now synchronized so trains could operate more efficiently. The factories were also happy because people now knew exactly when to arrive at work and when to clock out. The factories needed people to operate machines and assembly lines, which required an education system that created obedient workers who followed processes and didn’t complain.

A school system was set up to this effect. Students were compelled to wear the same clothes, aptly called a uniform. Schools instituted bells to mark the start and end of a school period, creating a school schedule that closely resembled the factory schedule. It didn’t matter if you were engrossed in a topic — once the bell rang, you had to stop your work and go to the next class.

Punctuality at school was enforced in the same way as in factories. A standardized curriculum and assessment system was established to

mirror the uniformity and predictability required in factories. The focus was on literacy and numeracy. You couldn't simply study what brought you joy. While modern education has evolved in many ways, it remains haunted by its past.

Perhaps the most insidious element of modern education is that it remains almost entirely silent on the question of, "How can I become the person I am meant to be?" While career teachers exist and work experience is sometimes included, this comprises a very small percentage of school time. Schools remain a vehicle to teach compliance and offer little discussion on the bigger questions connected to developing a meaningful life.

Schools focus on defining the questions and asking for answers instead of teaching students how to ask difficult questions. Consequently, conformity usually prevails over authenticity. We are taught by implication to pay little attention to our deepest desires and the things that we intensely enjoy. We have been conditioned to suppress these desires and instead focus on the symbols of success, our status, and appearance to others.

In practical terms, how many times have you been in a meeting where you were looking at the clock, begging time to move faster so that you could leave? You struggle to get through the day when time is used purely for an instrumental purpose, creating an insipid and monotonous experience. Is this the type of work that you want to be doing for the rest of your life? What is the dollar value of slowly enjoying each moment of your work? How valuable is it to connect deeply to the energy in each activity?

At some point in history, it seems like we all started to hurry up. As you move faster, it's easy to delude yourself into believing that you are making progress. The way to escape this delusion is to ask, "Where am I going?" The truth is that there is nowhere to go. When you look back at your life, do you want it to have been a rush toward death? Did Ivan Ilych, on his deathbed, count the boxes he ticked? A fulfilling life is not a counting competition. How do you measure inner peace, the joy of

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friendship, or the gratification of knowing you have deeply impacted another person's life? Fulfillment arises from developing your ability to feel each moment deeply and grow through the process.

The Riches in Each Moment

You might feel destined to live in a mechanical world, completing clinical tasks to achieve objectives on time and on budget. But is there a way to stop treating time as something to buy and sell? Choosing your work is about recognizing the irreplaceable nature of time. Let's examine the value of time by considering a few scenarios.

What's the difference between someone who goes on a luxurious vacation — first-class flights, five-star hotels — but spends their time feeling miserable, whining, and bitterly moaning about petty complaints, and someone who goes on a budget vacation — perhaps camping, flying economy, or staying at an inexpensive hotel — but spends their time smiling, laughing, in awe, and grateful for the experience? Is first class more comfortable than economy? Yes, it is. But does traveling first class create a better vacation? No, it does not. Luxury, however nice it may be, can never replace the joy that is found in each moment.

What's the difference between a house and a home? Imagine an opulent house with marble floors, designer furniture, and a state-of-the-art kitchen. But the luxury is stained by bitter arguments, long silences, and unresolved conflicts. The unspoken tension and emotional distance rob the swimming pool and tennis court of their appeal. Now imagine a humble home where the aroma of a home-cooked meal fills the kitchen, laughter reverberates through the hallways, and conversations are filled with joy.

What's the difference between mechanically playing memorized notes and delivering a musical performance? Imagine someone forced by their parents to practice piano daily, who can play scales with perfect technical precision. Compare that to someone who expresses their own interpretation of a particular piano piece and plays it with their entire body.

Now let's apply this concept to choosing your work. What's the difference between a random job and your true work? Imagine someone who toils without any emotion, who engages in a sterile trade of time for money, who is purely rational. Compare that to someone doing work that gives them energy, who radiates joy from the activity, who uses their natural strengths, and then leaves work fulfilled and wanting more.

The difference in these situations lies in the contrasting experiences of the inner journey and the outer journey.

The War Between Your Inner and Outer Journeys

The inner journey is about how you feel. Is there joy in each moment, or are you feeling anxious and stressed? It's the sensations in your body. Are you feeling light and full of energy, or are you feeling tense and burdened? It's the depth of your thinking. Are you coming up with fresh, new ideas, or are you repeating mechanical and monotonous tasks?

How do you feel when you fully express yourself? Learn that feeling. Remember the sensations you feel in your body. Treasure these moments. When you tap into your unique creative expression, not only does it feel right, but it produces something special. In a state of relaxed concentration, you are more likely to find unexpected connections between seemingly unrelated ideas. You will naturally and intuitively create your best work.

But we've been sold the idea that life is a series of outer journeys, and for many people, this becomes their experience when they disconnect from their true self. They have been taught that success consists of looking good, dressing well, owning a luxury home, and going on expensive vacations.

The inner journey is about self-acceptance. The outer journey is about external validation. If external validation becomes a priority, self-acceptance suffers.

How much energy do you want to spend on appearances, showing the world, "Hey look! I am successful!" with fancy clothes, watches, cars,

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and the like? In contrast, how much energy do you want to invest in crafting beautiful experiences? How much energy do you want to spend answering the question, “How do I feel about each moment?” Do you want to be captivated by the mystery or seduced by the manifestation?

What is the greatest luxury imaginable? Winning millions in the lottery? A huge house? A fancy vacation?

No. The greatest luxury is to live a life that is a complete expression of your true self.

When it comes to our work, why do we downplay the risk of painful dissatisfaction yet magnify the threat of financial uncertainty? Why do we default to prioritizing the outer journey over the inner journey?

During my brief stint in the corporate world, I once flew to another city for a consulting project. A co-worker strolled into work one morning complaining about how her five-star hotel didn’t have feather pillows, so she had to sleep on a regular pillow. Her face was twisted in a scowl, and it was obvious the experience had visibly soured her mood. It was this type of environment — where outer appearances mattered more than results — that led me to leave the corporate world after just a few months.

To be clear, there’s nothing wrong with wanting a beautiful house and expensive vacations. These are very reasonable goals worthy of your effort, if that’s what you desire. But if that’s all you focus on, you will miss out on something far greater. It’s like developing the perfect online presence on social media while neglecting to nurture genuine relationships offline. Similarly, imagine flying to a destination renowned for its breathtaking nature, investing in a scenic bus trip, and then spending the entire trip arguing with other passengers over seating instead of appreciating the stunning views. The purpose of the outer journey is merely to facilitate the inner journey. The outer journey is nothing more than a vessel for an enriching inner journey.

One major reason we feel consumed by the outer journey is because of the quantification bias.

How to Overcome the Quantification Bias

Consider the story of James, who from an early age was obsessed with projecting an image of success. After graduating from an elite college, he worked in a high-paying corporate job he didn't particularly enjoy. The salary allowed him to pay his sister's medical bills, something that mattered to him deeply. As James climbed the ranks, his promotions afforded the luxuries he craved — a BMW, tailored suits, and memberships in exclusive clubs. To fund it all, James worked punishing hours, neglecting both his health and relationships. At night, he would often lie awake, haunted by a deep-seated feeling of emptiness as the silence of his massive house echoed back his unresolved anxieties.

James owned a huge home designed to entertain guests and flaunt his materialistic accomplishments. Yet behind the shiny facade, he constantly felt anxious, unsettled, and disconnected from his work. The handful of interests he once enjoyed faded as work consumed his time and drained his energy. In his loneliest moments, which occurred almost daily, he wondered whether his relentless pursuit of success was really worth it. He felt like he had a pebble in his emotional shoe but didn't know how to remove it. The intense pressure led to frequent migraines and creeping hypertension, warning signs he routinely ignored to meet his next business target. James was obsessed with "What do I want?" to the detriment of "How do I feel?"

James needed money so much because he knew himself so little. The pursuit of money justified his avoidance of meaningful self-reflection.

While helping his sister made James feel good, it was outweighed by the painful discovery that no amount of quantifiable success in his outer journey could compensate for the gaping void in his inner journey. Winning the wrong game only magnifies the inherent emptiness of playing it.

Compare James with Alyssa. Alyssa didn't care about fancy possessions or social status. She worked a modest, part-time job in insurance that paid the bills, but her true calling was her side hustle. She crafted rustic furniture from reclaimed wood and other materials.

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Alyssa sometimes wondered if she'd made a mistake turning down full-time job offers. But every time she stepped into her workshop, the doubt melted away and she got lost in the therapeutic, tactile creative process.

For Alyssa, success was an inward endeavor. It was about self-expression, ornamenting the world with her unique creativity and delighting customers who could sense the life she breathed into each piece. When Alyssa faced difficulties, she always reminded herself why she chose her work, enabling her to see no challenge as insurmountable. Alyssa wanted the business to grow, but even if it stayed small, she knew she would still feel satisfied with her work at the end of each day.

James optimized for the outer journey, but despite being financially successful, his daily subjective experience was to suffer in comfort. Alyssa optimized for the inner journey. She wasn't wealthy by conventional standards, yet she richly enjoyed each moment in a way that James could not even imagine. While James tossed and turned in bed, stressed by the day's events and woke up poorly rested, Alyssa slept peacefully and deeply, rising with boundless energy. Alyssa grasped an important distinction that James had overlooked — comfort is empty while peace is revitalizing.

James constantly operated from a sense of lack, forever chasing more to fill an emptiness he couldn't articulate. Alyssa, in stark contrast, understood that she was already complete and that everything she accomplished was merely an extra gift. She moved through life like she was playing with house money, approaching each day with joy and curiosity rather than anxiety or desperation.

Alyssa was aware of the quantification bias, the psychological tendency to overvalue the things that can be quantified at the expense of those that cannot be measured. She observed that because money is easily quantified, it tends to be overvalued at the expense of well-being metrics that resist concrete measurement. She realized that our failure to widely quantify attributes like energy levels, creative output, and inner peace may obscure their significance, but this does not diminish their importance.

Alyssa understood that while money is replaceable, time is irreplaceable.

There is a sequel to this story. Alyssa's drive to produce high-quality artwork resulted in more and more client referrals. As demand increased, she quit her part-time job and hired others to assist her. Her mother fretted about the uncertainty, pleading with her to keep the insurance job for "just one more year."

But Alyssa could sense the momentum, so she quit her job and doubled down on what was working. Before she knew it, she had ten full-time staff. She made more money than she could spend. There were also economic downturns and, at times, her business suffered. Despite the challenges of running a business, Alyssa never rushed her work and always enjoyed giving full attention to her creative expression. After all, the primary reason she went into business was to enjoy delighting customers with unique artwork.

As you reflect on the contrasting journeys of James and Alyssa, consider which elements of their lives mirror your own. Are you drawn to the allure of sophisticated outward appearances like James? Or do you align more with Alyssa's approach, prioritizing the inner journey over the outer journey, placing a premium on the creative process, and finding meaning in the impact your work has on others?

To embody Alyssa's experience, ask, "In which specific activities have I been completely present? What experiences have I had where time stopped?" Make a list. Then choose the most important activity for you. Carve out sacred time for that activity and observe how you feel before, during, and after that activity. Then use the quality of that experience to question how you will spend the rest of your day. What needs to change?

If nothing changes, the best you can hope for is to suffer in comfort.

How to Stop Suffering in Comfort

A conqueror once invaded a village and imprisoned most of its men. Among the villagers were four philanthropists.

CHOOSE YOUR WORK

The first philanthropist went to the conqueror and said, “I understand the men do not have clean water, so I would like to donate purified water to the men.” And he was granted that.

The second philanthropist said, “I understand the men don’t get much food, so I would like to donate more food to the men.” And he was granted that.

The third philanthropist said, “I understand the men are often cold at night, so I would like to donate clothes and blankets.” And he was granted that.

Then the fourth philanthropist came along. He wasn’t as financially successful as the other philanthropists, but he possessed great wisdom. He found the prison keys and released the men.

This story highlights how a highly successful outer journey may still amount to nothing more than suffering in comfort. But in real life, no one hands you the keys. You must find them yourself.

The way to break out of prison is to let go of the outer journey. Observe the self-imposed prison walls that you have built in your life. What are you doing to look good at the expense of feeling good?

To escape a “life of quiet desperation,” as Thoreau put it, you must first look inward. The mere act of self-reflection makes space for you to choose your work. It’s the first step to preventing you from becoming a muffled voice that resides in safety and whispers in monotones. As you start to crystallize your preferences, you resist the false dreams that are centered on an outer journey. And as you begin to take action, you stop yourself from suffering in comfort.

Real success is about knowing how to spend your energy so that peace, joy, and excitement pervade your days. As you discover the peaks of joy and the valleys of sorrow, you realize that we have been oversold the value of comfort, and that it’s not your top priority. Indeed, many valuable experiences cannot be purchased with money, which explains the conspicuous absence of money from the list of top regrets of the dying.

What Money Can Never Buy

Anything created by money alone is not a real solution. It's a hack. A quick fix. Real solutions are only produced through sweat and tears. Progress must be earned. It cannot be bought. History is filled with examples.

The first modern aircraft did not come from any of the well-financed attempts. To the contrary, it was built by the owners of a small bicycle shop! The Wright brothers were neither scientists nor engineers. They were, however, fiercely determined and deeply curious. Amazingly, their hands-on mechanical skills from repairing bicycles were enough to get them going. By using the modest profits from their bicycle shop, they built their own wind tunnel to run experiments on aerodynamics. From these experiments, they were able to invent, build, and fly the first motor aircraft.

Stephen King wrote his breakthrough novel *Carrie* while living in a cramped trailer and working as a schoolteacher, barely earning enough to support his family. Henri Rousseau worked as a toll collector, earning a meager income, but this did not deter him from creating world-class paintings, which gained admiration from avant-garde artists like Pablo Picasso. Steve Wozniak and Steve Jobs, the co-founders of Apple, started by assembling computers in a garage. They initially financed the Apple I by selling personal items, including Wozniak's scientific calculator and Jobs' Volkswagen van. Sylvester Stallone wrote the screenplay for *Rocky* in 1971 while he was virtually broke. He even had to sell his dog for \$50 to help pay the bills. Fortunately, he was able to buy his dog back for \$3,000 after the movie's success.

As you reflect on these examples, observe how, paradoxically, the lack of money sharpened commitment and enhanced resourcefulness. Instead of suffering in comfort, these people excelled in discomfort. King's unwavering determination to complete his novel kept him writing despite his financial challenges and uncertain future. Steve Wozniak and Steve Jobs were so intent on building Apple that they were willing to sell off some of their personal possessions. Henri Rousseau had to paint, while Sylvester Stallone had to write *Rocky*, even if it meant living in poverty.

The freedom gained from choosing captivating work far outweighs any freedom that money can buy.

Finding the Freedom to Choose Your Work

Did Sylvester Stallone enjoy selling his dog? No, it must have been horrible to have to do that. But he did what he needed to do to survive, and thankfully, he got his dog back.

Now, it's very unlikely you will be forced to sell your dog. But when you choose your work, sacrifices will need to be made. It won't be easy, nor will it be comfortable. But it will feel *right*. You will know that you have chosen *your* work when you are on the path of greatest satisfaction, not the path of least resistance. As you look back, you'll know that you did something that mattered; you created an enduring memory. You will be glad that you let go of the average to make space for the exceptional. As you step into the unknown, you discover that everything important is created in the field of uncertainty.

When you let go of the familiar and embark on your own journey, there will be moments when you will feel inspired and other times when you will feel frustrated. But as you follow the path, you realize that the elevations and depressions are not to be feared or even taken too seriously. You learn to see beyond the peaks and the valleys, because deep beyond the horizon lies something far more profound than anything you can see with your eyes. A light. A vision. A true sense of peace, which no form of artificial comfort can provide. So you stay steadfast in your approach, committed to a path that you know has your back, that will provide the ultimate security for your future.

While the path may not always appear clear, just the act of beginning on that path is a very powerful thing to do because, as the Persian philosopher Rumi said, "As you walk the path, the pathway reveals itself." Once you start the journey, you will gain momentum, you will learn new things, and with each step, the next step will become clearer. That's why Rumi also said, "What you are seeking is also seeking you."

DON'T CONFUSE SUCCESS WITH SUFFERING IN COMFORT

When you choose to do something that matters to you, you are tapping into a more profound desire than your personal wants. If you are, for example, innovating in the field of science, every scientist is cheering you on because they too care about innovations in the field of science.

What I've come to realize is this —

In the pursuit of success, we often look in the wrong places.

*We search for luxury,
But the real beauty lies within your inner journey.*

*We crave comfort,
But the real beauty unfolds as you become who you are meant to be.*

*We seek praise and compliments,
But the real beauty is found simply in doing work that breathes
life into your being.*

*We look outside for validation,
But the real beauty is discovered on the silent journey inward.*

*It's the stillness of peace,
And the melody of harmony.*

*It's the pulse of energy flowing through you,
And the dance of your creative spirit.*

*It's the quiet softness of joy,
And when your body reverberates with excitement.*

*So go explore the world,
Look outside at the endless possibilities it offers.*

*But know this —
Your deepest truth can only be experienced from the inside.*

Let's consider how this chapter applies to you with the upcoming reflection.

The Comfort Trap

- 1. In what ways does my current work encourage comfort and validation at the expense of fulfillment?*
- 2. If I had to choose one project that was more fulfilling, what would that project be?*

Duration

Two minutes

Revisit this reflection monthly as your work evolves. Set a reminder to review your thoughts each month to see how your work may have shifted.

These prompts are short by design, but feel free to take longer if you're uncovering something important.

-

In the Next Chapter...

Hopefully, you now feel more liberated to choose your work. But what are the practical steps to make this happen? We will explore this in the next chapter.

Praise for *Choose Your Work*

Choose Your Work is both deeply personal and profoundly universal. It is insightful, provocative, and quietly unsettling. It seamlessly blends research and real-world anecdotes with practical, step-by-step guidance to help you identify what matters most. This is a book for anyone who has ever sensed there must be more — more meaning, more joy, more alignment between who they are and the work they do.

Genia Janover | Award-Winning Former Principal | Bialik College | Former Fellow | Australian College of Educators

Dan Dobos says the scary, quiet thing out loud: how we spend our working lives is a choice. *Choose Your Work* is both a wake-up call and a practical roadmap for anyone ready to make that choice.

Ben Stickland | Co-Founder & CEO | Instamove

This is the kind of book I will go back to regularly. Some self-help books you read once. Others bring value over and over throughout your life. This is the latter.

Teshia Harding

Choose Your Work distills a lifetime of insights and wisdom into a practical guide to help you clarify what matters most.

Jonar Nader | Former IBM Executive | Author of *How to Lose Friends & Infuriate Your Boss*

Chapter Two alone helped me more than therapy has.

Kayla Giles

Choose Your Work is a timely and deeply needed guide for anyone who senses there must be more to work than simply earning a living. In a volatile world that pushes people toward conformity, this book offers a practical and thought-provoking path back to what truly matters.

Mark Bowles | Dean, Tasmanian School of Business and Economics | University of Tasmania

In my work as a psychotherapist, I see how easy it is to lose sight of who you truly are. *Choose Your Work* offers a thoughtful and compelling path back to yourself.

Kirk Fisher | Psychotherapist & Zen Teacher

Honest, raw, and real. *Choose Your Work* was exactly what I needed.

Christy Oshima

Unlike other career change manuals, this is a guide for those searching for fulfilling work that is both optimistic and encouraging.

Helen Praetz | Emeritus Professor and Former Pro Vice-Chancellor | RMIT University

If you know someone graduating college, buy them this book. If a friend just turned 30, buy them this book. Most people stumble into careers that 'kinda work' and there they remain stuck. Don't be like most people. Buy this book.

James Tuckerman | Founder | Anthill Magazine

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**Have you ever felt the unnerving sensation that,
despite appearing successful, something deep down isn't quite right?**

When you look back at your life, will you be satisfied?
Or will you have regrets?

The dark side of grit is chasing goals that don't matter,
while your deepest desires quietly fade away.

The way forward is to realize that the secret to a
fulfilling life is to choose your work.

**In this thought-provoking book, packed with inspiration,
practical strategies, and insightful stories, you will discover...**

What is more valuable than \$100 million in cold hard cash?

•

How to extract insights from your greatest challenges to realize your potential

•

Strategies to choose your work while still paying the bills

•

Why being good at something may lead you down the
wrong path and how to find the right one

•

Why focusing on comfort can ruin your life and
obscure the true metrics of success



**This book will help you discover your deepest truth, redefine what
success means to you, and begin a fulfilling new chapter in your journey.**

"Compelling and thought-provoking. It inspired immediate action in my life."

Beau Florenosos

"Inspirational, memorable and unlike any self-help book I've read before."

Jean Rose Dogillo

"Engaging, energising and deeply thought-provoking."

Liz Treat